

Exits in the UK: Acquisitions & IPOs

An exploration into the acquisitions and IPOs completed by high-growth UK companies since 2011, in collaboration with Triple Point.

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Acquisitions and IPOs
2011–2021

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In spite of the unexpected turbulence caused by COVID-19, a rapid recovery in the number of acquisitions and IPOs in 2021 points towards a promising future.

Here, we explore the types of companies leaving the high-growth ecosystem, the format of exits taking place, and the valuations accompanying them.

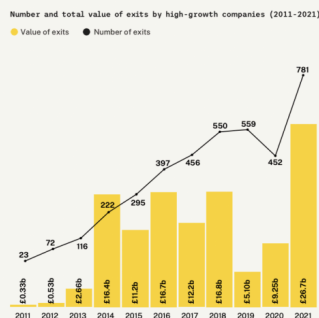
Here's a sneak peek inside

Exits over time and types of exit

Between 2011 and 2021 there was a significant increase in both the number and value of exits completed by UK high-growth companies. The compound annual growth rate for the combined value of exits was 55.2% across these 10 years, reflecting the health of the UK's high-growth economy. Unsurprisingly,

exit figures experienced some turbulence during 2019 and 2020 – caused by the COVID-19 pandemic and ongoing economic uncertainties due to the UK's departure from the European Union. Despite the total value of exits plummeting by 70% to £5.8b in 2019, marking a five-year low, the total value

rebounded by the end of 2021 – increasing by 423% to £26.7b. As detailed on the following pages, both acquisitions and IPOs saw a dramatic uptick in 2021.



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Average prices

Since 2011, mean exit valuations for high-growth companies undertaking an IPO have been volatile. These figures have the capacity to fluctuate by over 100% each year, mostly caused by individual high-value exits that inflate annual statistics. Despite this turbulence, there has been an overall growth in the average value of IPOs during this 10-year period, caused by an unprecedented amount of capital available to private companies prior to going public.

At the beginning of the same decade, exit valuations for acquired companies had less annual variation and a more modest growth trajectory. However, over the past three years, this figure has experienced a similar degree of turbulence as that observed for IPOs – most likely influenced by macroeconomic factors such as Brexit and the COVID-19 pandemic, including the associated economic stimulus.

This turbulence has also been accompanied by a significant increase in the mean exit valuation for acquisitions. Prior to 2018, this number peaked at £37m in 2015, as acquisition values remained distinctly lower than those achieved by companies that underwent an IPO. However, in 2019 the mean valuation for companies that were acquired shot to £282m, and subsequently peaked in 2021 at £364m.

Mean exit valuations for high-growth companies (2011-2021)



32.3%
CAGR of mean IPO exit valuations for high-growth companies (2012-2021)

28.4%
CAGR of mean acquisition exit valuations for high-growth companies (2012-2021)

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Daniel conducts data manipulation, visualisation and analysis as part of the Research & Consultancy team. He has a background in business analysis and commercial copywriting in Australia and the

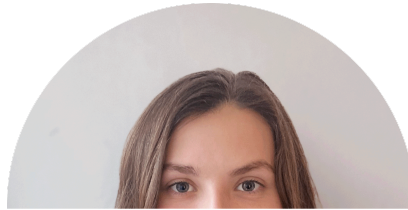




FREYA HYDE

Freya performs data analysis and visualisation in the Research & Consultancy team, with a focus on design, and has worked on projects for Barclays, EY and JP Morgan. She holds a BA in History (International) from the University of Leeds, which included a year at Fudan University in Shanghai.

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